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In 2021, after successfully hosting the Indian Premier League (IPL) for the second consecutive year amid the global Covid-19 pandemic, then BCCI treasurer Arun Singh Dhumal praised the UAE venues, likening them to “the best banquet you could have for any celebration.”

With much of the world in lockdown, few expected the IPL to proceed, but the Emirates Cricket Board (ECB), with strong government support, ensured the tournament ran smoothly in 2020 and again in 2021 across Dubai, Abu Dhabi, and Sharjah. The UAE also hosted the 2021 Men's T20 World Cup, with India holding the hosting rights.

Now, as Dubai and Sharjah prepare to host the Women's T20 World Cup — the first global women's cricket event in the region — Dhumal, currently chairman of the IPL's governing council, still stands by

his statement.

Dhumal credits the UAE's world-class facilities, accessibility, and professional approach for establishing it as a premier cricketing destination. “During COVID, when no one imagined we could go ahead with a tournament like the IPL, they ensured everything was prim and proper. Those two years have certainly helped the UAE build a positive image. The stakeholders have understood that the UAE not only has all the facilities but also the expertise to get things sorted in a very short period,” Dhumal explained.

That expertise has helped what many now call the ‘UAE model’ thrive.

Despite being an associate member of the International Cricket Council (ICC), the UAE has projected itself as a prime destination for cricket, often considered an alternative venue for major events during times of crisis. This year's Women's T20 World Cup is a case in point.

Originally, Bangladesh was slated to host the event. However, political turmoil, followed by the fleeing of then-Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, forced the ICC to seek an alternative location, although the hosting rights

remained with the Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB).

“The travel advisories from the governments of several participating teams meant it wasn't feasible (to host the event in Bangladesh),” explained ICC's chief executive, Geoff Allardice. The ICC explored other options. India, which shares a similar time zone with Bangladesh, was considered a possible host. However, with its home season in full swing, the BCCI declined. Eventually, the UAE emerged as the preferred choice.

“After India refused to host the tournament, we had discussions with the UAE and Sri Lanka, but the former was preferred for several reasons. The UAE has hosted several big-ticket tournaments recently, and it was also convenient to hold the games there,” said BCB president Faruque Ahmed, who recently visited Dubai to oversee the preparations.

“Logistically, it's convenient,” said Ahmed. “For the teams, it's easy to travel to the UAE in terms of accessibility. Also, we have two top-quality stadiums nearby, and that's a huge advantage for a high-octane tournament.”

The 10 participating teams will be based in Dubai, a city with approximately 180 five-star hotels.

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